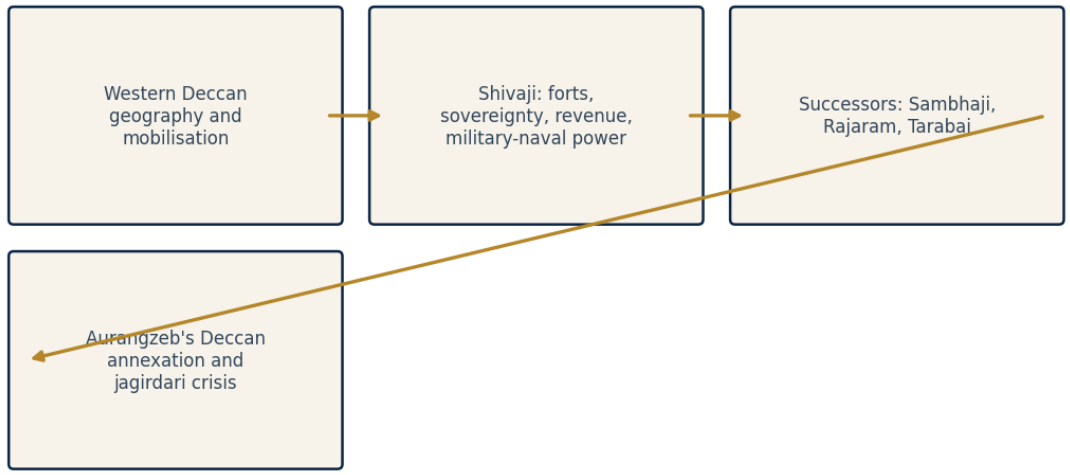
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Medieval History Topic 23 - The Marathas, Shivaji & Aurangzeb's Deccan; Jagirdari Crisis - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC solved practice workbook | Foundation to advanced | MCQs, PYQs and model Mains answers for exam application

TOPIC 23 — THE MARATHAS, SHIVAJI & AURANGZEB'S DECCAN; JAGIRDARI CRISIS

Cover overview



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Topic 23 - Solved Practice Workbook

Complementary to the Learning Session bank: this workbook uses statement, matching, chronology, application, evidence and inference item types at an advanced level, with no verbatim or near-clone overlap with the Learning-Session MCQs.

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WORKBOOK MCQ BANK

Exactly 32 MCQs; correct-option rotation is A, B, C, D repeated 8 times. Each item carries four option-specific explanations (128 total) and one distinct item-specific trap.

Q1. *[statement]* Which statement about zamindars, deshmukhs and local armed groups after 1680 is accurate?

- A. Their bargaining position let them extract advantage from parallel Mughal-Maratha revenue claims rather than acting as simple, uniform officials.
- B. They were uniformly loyal Mughal officials with no independent bargaining power.
- C. They functioned only as landlords with no administrative role whatsoever.
- D. Every locality responded identically to Mughal-Maratha pressure, regardless of the local balance of power.

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: local actors used bargaining leverage amid parallel collection rather than behaving as one uniform category.
- **B.** Wrong: local actors bargained, resisted or made private pacts rather than acting as uniformly loyal officials.
- **C.** Wrong: they combined administrative, military and local-authority roles, not a pure landlord function.
- **D.** Wrong: the topic explicitly cautions against homogenising local society - outcomes depended on locality.

Trap: Treating a bargaining, locally variable actor as a single uniform category (official, landlord, or otherwise) is the trap.

Q2. *[statement]* Which statement about Maratha political mobilisation is defensible?

- A. It was a purely primordial Hindu-nationalist movement from its origin.
- B. It drew on deshmukhs, Mavalis, cavalry households, administrators and Deccani service personnel without being one homogeneous bloc.
- C. It excluded all Muslim or Deccani service personnel by design.
- D. It was organised exclusively by Brahman administrators with no peasant or cavalry role.

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: this projects modern nationalism backward onto a plural service-and-locality coalition.

- **B.** Correct: the coalition was plural and its members' interests could overlap without being identical.
- **C.** Wrong: Deccani and Muslim personnel served within the same networks.
- **D.** Wrong: Mavalis and cavalry households were integral, not absent.

Trap: Collapsing a plural coalition into a single identity label is the fatal trap.

Q3. *[matching]* Match the historiographical frame to its accurate limitation.

- A. Communal frame -> is fully validated with no institutional counter-evidence.
- B. Regional-state frame -> denies that forts or revenue mattered to state formation.
- C. Nationalist frame -> risks importing modern nation-state language onto a regional polity.
- D. Peasant/zamindar frame -> proves the ruler and court had no independent role.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: Persianate institutions and Muslim officers complicate an exclusive Hindu-reaction frame.
- **B.** Wrong: the regional-state frame is precisely built on forts, revenue and legitimacy.
- **C.** Correct: it captures anti-imperial memory but over-reads modern nationhood.
- **D.** Wrong: this frame highlights local power but must not dissolve the court into an automatic uprising.

Trap: Assuming any one frame is complete on its own, rather than bounded, is the trap.

Q4. *[chronology]* Which chronological sequence is correct?

- A. Treaty of Purandar (1665) -> Javli (1656) -> Afzal Khan's death (1659).
- B. Agra detention (1666) -> Javli (1656) -> Treaty of Purandar (1665).
- C. Afzal Khan's death (1659) -> Agra detention (1666) -> Javli (1656).
- D. Javli (1656) -> Afzal Khan's death (1659) -> Treaty of Purandar (1665) -> Agra detention (1666).

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: Javli and Afzal Khan both preceded Purandar.
- **B.** Wrong: Agra came after, not before, Javli and Purandar.
- **C.** Wrong: Javli preceded Afzal Khan's death, not the reverse.
- **D.** Correct: this follows the secured chronology of early consolidation and Mughal contact.

Trap: Reordering well-known events without checking the exact year is the trap.

Q5. *[chronology]* Which chronological sequence for Aurangzeb's Deccan phase is correct?

- A. Bijapur annexed (1686) -> Golconda annexed (1687) -> Sambhaji executed (1689) -> Gingee falls (1698).
- B. Golconda annexed (1687) -> Bijapur annexed (1686) -> Gingee falls (1698).
- C. Sambhaji executed (1689) -> Bijapur annexed (1686) -> Golconda annexed (1687).
- D. Gingee falls (1698) -> Sambhaji executed (1689) -> Bijapur annexed (1686).

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: annexation preceded Sambhaji's execution, and Gingee fell only in 1698.
- **B.** Wrong: Bijapur fell in 1686, before Golconda in 1687.
- **C.** Wrong: the annexations preceded Sambhaji's execution.
- **D.** Wrong: this reverses the entire sequence.

Trap: Placing Gingee's fall before Sambhaji's execution is the specific trap tested here.

Q6. *[evidence]* Which is the strongest use of European factory records for Surat, 1664?

- A. They provide an official Maratha revenue ledger for the raid.

- B. They document commercial disruption and rumour, useful for trade impact but not neutral on Maratha motive.
- C. They are entirely fictional and carry no evidentiary value.
- D. They settle the exact amount looted with certainty.

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: factory records are a merchant/commercial source, not a Maratha administrative ledger.
- **B.** Correct: factory records carry merchant interests and must be read for what they can and cannot show.
- **C.** Wrong: they are genuinely useful for commercial disruption, just not for motive.
- **D.** Wrong: exact loot figures require source-by-source verification, not one account.

Trap: Treating a merchant source as a neutral, comprehensive record is the trap.

Q7. *[evidence]* What is the correct evidentiary status of UNESCO's Maratha Military Landscapes listing?

- A. It is direct primary evidence for every Maratha battle.
- B. It proves the exact size of Shivaji's forces at each fort.
- C. A 2025 static heritage fact naming twelve component forts, usable only as a bounded bridge into the historical argument.
- D. It is identical in date and content to the 2026 PIB conservation release.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: heritage listing does not narrate or verify specific tactical episodes.
- **B.** Wrong: force-size claims require period military/administrative sources, not a heritage listing.
- **C.** Correct: heritage recognition supports present significance, not seventeenth-century tactical proof.
- **D.** Wrong: the two are distinct and dated separately (2025 listing vs 2026 conservation update).

Trap: Merging a static 2025 heritage fact with a dated 2026 administrative update is the trap.

Q8. *[application]* An answer describes Shivaji's fort administration as run solely by the Ashtapradhan from the capital. What is the correct fix?

- A. Delete all reference to fort administration entirely.
- B. Replace the Ashtapradhan with a claim that Peshwa-era institutions ran the forts.
- C. Assert that forts had no administrative checks of any kind.
- D. Add the local havaldar/sabnis fort-command roles that provided day-to-day, fort-level administrative checks alongside the central offices.

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: fort administration is a required part of the state-structure answer, not a point to omit.
- **B.** Wrong: this projects a later Peshwa-era institution backward onto Shivaji's own reign.
- **C.** Wrong: named fort-level roles supplied real administrative checks; their absence is not accurate.
- **D.** Correct: this restores the fort-local layer of administration that the central offices alone do not capture.

Trap: Collapsing fort-level administration entirely into the central Ashtapradhan is the trap.

Q9. *[application]* An answer asserts that Dadoji Konddev single-handedly designed Shivaji's entire state and that Jija Bai's political role is fully documented in precise detail. What is the correct fix?

- A. Discuss Dadoji Konddev only as a secure administrative actor in the Poona setting and treat Jija Bai's household legitimacy and authority without overstating exact political direction beyond the record.
- B. Remove both figures from the account entirely to avoid any attribution question.
- C. Assert that neither figure has any place in a secure account of the period.
- D. Claim Jija Bai personally commanded military campaigns without qualification.

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: this matches the required source-critical, bounded treatment of both figures.
- **B.** Wrong: both figures belong in a secure account; the issue is over-attribution, not their presence.
- **C.** Wrong: this wrongly denies figures who do have a secure, if bounded, evidentiary role.
- **D.** Wrong: this invents a specific military-command claim not supported by the record.

Trap: Turning a bounded, source-critical attribution into either an inflated single-author claim or a total erasure is the trap.

Q10. *[application]* How should an answer use the Agra basket-escape story?

- A. Assert the basket story as an officially verified administrative record.
- B. Present the crisis and escape as secure, and label the basket detail's exact provenance rather than asserting it as certain fact.
- C. Omit the escape from Agra entirely to avoid controversy.
- D. Claim Aurangzeb personally arranged the escape as a trap.

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: it is a popular narrative detail, not a verified administrative record.
- **B.** Correct: this keeps the secure core separate from a contested narrative detail.
- **C.** Wrong: the escape itself is a secure and necessary part of the account.
- **D.** Wrong: this invents a motive not supported by the source record.

Trap: Confusing a popular legend's detail with a documented administrative fact is the trap.

Q11. *[application]* How should an answer treat the 'Aurangzeb won Bijapur and Golconda but lost the Deccan' phrase?

- A. Quote it as an official Mughal court verdict on the war.
- B. Use it to claim the annexations achieved nothing at all.
- C. Use it as an analytical paradox distinguishing map-conquest from governable, revenue-realising authority.
- D. Treat it as proof that religion was the sole cause of the war.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: it is a modern historiographical formulation, not a contemporary court judgment.
- **B.** Wrong: the annexations were real territorial and administrative gains, just costly ones.
- **C.** Correct: this captures the phrase's intended analytical function.
- **D.** Wrong: the phrase concerns governance and logistics, not religious motivation specifically.

Trap: Reading an analytical paradox as either a contemporary quotation or a single-cause verdict is the trap.

Q12. *[application]* A student conflates be-jagiri with the jama-hasil gap. What is the correct distinction?

- A. They are two names for exactly the same phenomenon.
- B. Be-jagiri refers only to naval assignments.
- C. The jama-hasil gap describes a surplus of jagirs over claimants.
- D. Be-jagiri is a shortage of assignable productive jagirs; the jama-hasil gap is assessed revenue exceeding what is actually collected.

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: one concerns jagir supply, the other concerns assessment-versus-collection on an assigned jagir.

- **B.** Wrong: be-jagiri concerns land/revenue assignments generally, not naval matters.
- **C.** Wrong: it describes a revenue shortfall, not a surplus of jagirs.
- **D.** Correct: the two describe different points of failure in the same system.

Trap: Merging distinct fiscal-administrative terms into one blurred concept is the trap.

Q13. *[inference]* What is the best inference from the mixed cash-plunder-assignment military remuneration system?

- A. Maratha military capacity rested on a flexible mix of pay forms, not a single modern salaried model.
- B. Soldiers were entirely unpaid volunteers motivated only by ideology.
- C. Only plunder sustained the army, with no cash or assignment component.
- D. The system proves a fully centralised modern treasury existed.

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: mixed remuneration explains sustained mobilisation without assuming a uniform bureaucratic payroll.
- **B.** Wrong: cash pay and assignments show material, not purely ideological, motivation.
- **C.** Wrong: cash-paid regulars existed alongside plunder shares and assignments.
- **D.** Wrong: mixed, flexible remuneration is the opposite of a single centralised modern payroll.

Trap: Collapsing a mixed system into one single (all-cash or all-plunder) caricature is the trap.

Q14. *[inference]* What is the best inference from Panhala's siege and the Salher battle together?

- A. Maratha forces never engaged in any siege or set battle.
- B. Mobile Maratha warfare (ganimi kava) coexisted with genuine siege defence and pitched battle capacity.
- C. Ganimi kava was abandoned permanently after Panhala.
- D. Sieges always ended in immediate Maratha defeat.

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: Panhala (siege) and Salher (pitched battle) directly contradict this.
- **B.** Correct: the two episodes show tactical range beyond pure mobility.
- **C.** Wrong: mobile tactics continued to be used well beyond this period.
- **D.** Wrong: outcomes varied; Salher itself was a Maratha battlefield success.

Trap: Assuming 'guerrilla' tactics excluded all conventional warfare is the trap.

Q15. *[inference]* What is the best inference from Prince Akbar's alliance with Sambhaji during the succession struggle after 1680?

- A. It proves the entire Mughal nobility had defected to the Marathas.
- B. It shows Sambhaji had no independent political standing of his own.
- C. Internal Mughal succession tensions could intersect with Deccan politics, giving Sambhaji added leverage without guaranteeing an outcome.
- D. It confirms Aurangzeb abandoned the Deccan campaign immediately afterward.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: one prince's alliance does not establish a wholesale nobility defection.
- **B.** Wrong: Sambhaji held his own succession position independent of the alliance.
- **C.** Correct: this captures the interaction between Mughal dynastic tension and Deccan politics without overclaiming a guaranteed outcome.
- **D.** Wrong: Aurangzeb intensified, rather than abandoned, the Deccan campaign in this period.

Trap: Turning one political alliance into either a full defection claim or a change-of-campaign claim is the trap.

Q16. *[inference]* What is the best inference from Santaji Ghorpade and Dhanaji Jadhav's operations during the Gingee period?

- A. Maratha resistance depended on a single commander with no other operational leadership.
- B. Decentralised command produced no coordinated military activity at all.
- C. Their operations were confined only to naval engagements.
- D. Distributed, mobile commanders could sustain active operations even while the nominal ruler was based at a distant fort.

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: multiple named commanders, not one figure, sustained operations in this phase.
- **B.** Wrong: their campaigns show active, coordinated resistance despite dispersed command.
- **C.** Wrong: their operations were land-based mobile campaigns, not naval engagements.
- **D.** Correct: this matches the decentralised-command pattern that let resistance continue despite distance from Gingee.

Trap: Assuming decentralised leadership means an absence of effective, coordinated operations is the trap.

Q17. *[statement]* Which statement about Tarabai's regency is accurate?

- A. She led resistance as regent for her young son Shivaji II after Rajaram's death in 1700.
- B. She ruled in her own name with no dynastic justification.
- C. She was a purely ceremonial figure with no political authority.
- D. She succeeded Sambhaji directly, bypassing Rajaram entirely.

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: this names the dynastic basis of her authority correctly.
- **B.** Wrong: her authority was framed through her son Shivaji II's claim.
- **C.** Wrong: she organised legitimacy, patronage and resistance directly.
- **D.** Wrong: Rajaram reigned and died in 1700 before her regency began.

Trap: Omitting the dynastic basis (Shivaji II) of her regency is the trap.

Q18. *[statement]* Which statement about the Maratha fort network's function is accurate?

- A. Forts served only a ceremonial purpose with no operational role.
- B. A linked network of forts supplied storage, observation, signalling and short-radius movement that reinforced mobile military operations.
- C. Every fort operated in total isolation with no communication between them.
- D. Fort-holding was unrelated to revenue or supply considerations.

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: forts held stores, garrisons and observation functions, not merely ceremonial status.
- **B.** Correct: this matches the distributed, linked function of the fort network alongside mobile tactics.
- **C.** Wrong: forts could signal a neighbouring garrison, indicating a linked, not isolated, system.
- **D.** Wrong: forts anchored supply, storage and revenue-linked administration, not an unrelated function.

Trap: Reducing an interlinked operational network to isolated or purely ceremonial nodes is the trap.

Q19. *[statement]* Which statement about short jagirdar tenure and frequent transfers is accurate?

- A. Frequent transfers were designed to and successfully strengthened long-term troop maintenance.
- B. Short tenure had no effect on jagirdar behaviour at all.

- C. Transfers meant to prevent local entrenchment instead encouraged quick extraction, bribery and factional competition, weakening troop maintenance.
- D. Transfers were abolished entirely after the 1680s to fix the jagirdari crisis.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: the mechanism undermined, rather than strengthened, troop maintenance.
- **B.** Wrong: short tenure changed incentives toward quick extraction rather than leaving behaviour unaffected.
- **C.** Correct: this matches the documented perverse incentive created by frequent jagirdar transfers.
- **D.** Wrong: the topic does not record transfers being abolished as a fix during this period.

Trap: Assuming an anti-entrenchment measure automatically produced its intended stabilising effect is the trap.

Q20. *[statement]* Which statement about the 1663 Poona night raid on Shaista Khan is accurate?

- A. It permanently ended all Mughal military presence in the Deccan.
- B. It was a purely symbolic gesture with no effect on Mughal prestige or strategy.
- C. It proves the Marathas held a numerically larger force than the Mughals at all times.
- D. It demonstrated Maratha capability for a bold strike deep into an occupied position, damaging Mughal prestige without settling the war's wider strategic balance.

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: Mughal presence in the Deccan continued well beyond this raid.
- **B.** Wrong: the raid affected prestige and strategic calculation, not merely symbolic value.
- **C.** Wrong: the raid's significance rested on audacity and information, not overall numerical superiority.
- **D.** Correct: this captures the raid's real strategic and prestige effect without inflating it into a decisive military verdict.

Trap: Turning one bold raid into either a decisive end to Mughal presence or a merely symbolic gesture is the trap.

Q21. *[statement]* Which statement about paibaqi is accurate?

- A. It denotes land recorded as unassigned or awaiting assignment, whose paper status did not guarantee realised income.
- B. It denotes a fixed, guaranteed cash salary paid to every mansabdar.
- C. It is a synonym for be-jagiri with no distinct meaning.
- D. It refers exclusively to naval supply stores.

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: this is the precise, bounded definition required by the topic.
- **B.** Wrong: paibaqi concerns unassigned land status, not a guaranteed salary.
- **C.** Wrong: paibaqi concerns land-assignment status, distinct from the general jagir shortage named by be-jagiri.
- **D.** Wrong: paibaqi is a revenue/land-assignment term, not a naval logistics term.

Trap: Treating paibaqi as interchangeable with unrelated fiscal or naval terms is the trap.

Q22. *[matching]* Match the office to its core function in Shivaji's administration.

- A. Panditrao -> military command.
- B. Nyayadhish -> justice.
- C. Senapati -> correspondence and records.
- D. Sumant/Dabir -> accounts and finance.

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: Panditrao handled religious grants and duties, not military command.
- **B.** Correct: Nyayadhish held the specialised judicial function among the eight offices.
- **C.** Wrong: Senapati was the military commander; Sachiv handled correspondence/records.
- **D.** Wrong: Sumant/Dabir handled external/diplomatic affairs; Amatya/Mazumdar handled finance.

Trap: Swapping two named offices' functions is the specific trap in matching items.

Q23. *[matching]* Match the fiscal/administrative term to its accurate meaning.

- A. Hasil -> the assessed, uncollected demand.
- B. Be-jagiri -> a surplus of productive jagirs over claimants.
- C. Jama -> assessed (paper) revenue demand.
- D. Mansab -> a purely honorary title with no service obligation.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: hasil is revenue actually collected, the opposite of an uncollected paper figure.
- **B.** Wrong: be-jagiri names a shortage, not a surplus, of productive jagirs.
- **C.** Correct: jama is the assessed figure, distinct from actual collection.
- **D.** Wrong: mansab expressed rank tied to a real service obligation.

Trap: Reversing jama/hasil or inverting be-jagiri's direction is the trap.

Q24. *[matching]* Match the source genre to what it can reliably show.

- A. European factory records -> exact Maratha administrative revenue figures.
- B. Forts, coins and inscriptions -> a transparent narration of every battle.
- C. Sabhasad Bakhar -> a neutral, disinterested modern academic analysis.
- D. Mughal Persian chronicles -> imperial perception and campaign priorities.

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: factory records show commercial disruption and rumour, not internal Maratha ledgers.
- **B.** Wrong: material evidence shows capacity and legitimacy, not blow-by-blow narration.
- **C.** Wrong: it is an early courtly narrative requiring patronage/genre caution, not neutral academic writing.
- **D.** Correct: they show the state's own framing, including 'rebel/bandit' vocabulary.

Trap: Assigning a genre a capability it structurally cannot provide is the trap.

Q25. *[matching]* Match the annexation-era claimant group to its correct description.

- A. Absorbed Deccani nobles/soldiers -> displaced from Bijapur/Golconda service, adding new assignment claims.
- B. Mughal khanazads -> a group entirely excluded from mansab or jagir claims.
- C. Maratha or Maratha-origin mansabdars -> a group with no connection to jagir competition.
- D. Local zamindars -> officials with no bargaining role in revenue collection.

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: annexation displaced this group directly into Mughal mansab-jagir competition.
- **B.** Wrong: khanazads actively sought rank and assignments, adding to claimant pressure.
- **C.** Wrong: they were newly given mansabs and competed for productive jagirs like other claimants.
- **D.** Wrong: zamindars mediated, resisted or bargained over collection, a real bargaining role.

Trap: Erasing a named claimant group's actual role in the jagirdari pressure is the trap.

Q26. *[chronology]* Which sequence correctly places the coronation and southern expedition?

- A. Karnataka expedition (1676-79) -> coronation (1674) -> death (1680).
- B. Raigad coronation (1674) -> Karnataka/southern expedition (1676-79) -> Shivaji's death (1680).
- C. Death (1680) -> coronation (1674) -> Karnataka expedition (1676-79).
- D. Coronation (1674) -> death (1680) -> Karnataka expedition (1676-79).

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: the coronation preceded, not followed, the southern expedition.
- **B.** Correct: this is the secured order of these three anchors.
- **C.** Wrong: Shivaji's death necessarily came last, not first.
- **D.** Wrong: the expedition fell between the coronation and death, not after death.

Trap: Placing death before the campaigns that preceded it is the trap.

Q27. *[chronology]* Which sequence correctly places the fiscal/military crisis anchors?

- A. Acute jagirdari strain (1690s) -> Annaji Datto's assessment (1679).
- B. Bijapur/Golconda annexation (1686-87) -> Annaji Datto's assessment (1679).
- C. Annaji Datto's assessment (c.1679) -> Bijapur/Golconda annexation (1686-87) -> acute jagirdari strain (1690s-1700s).
- D. Jagirdari strain -> annexation -> Annaji Datto's assessment, in that order.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: the assessment came first, well before the acute strain.
- **B.** Wrong: the assessment preceded, not followed, the annexations.
- **C.** Correct: assessment preceded annexation, which intensified the jagirdari strain.
- **D.** Wrong: this reverses the entire correct order.

Trap: Reversing a cause-before-consequence chronology is the trap.

Q28. *[chronology]* Which sequence correctly places the succession after Shivaji's death?

- A. Tarabai's regency -> Sambhaji -> Rajaram, in that order.
- B. Rajaram -> Sambhaji -> Tarabai, in that order.
- C. Shivaji II ruled directly and immediately after Shivaji's death in 1680.
- D. Sambhaji (1680-89) -> Rajaram/Gingee -> Tarabai's regency for Shivaji II (from 1700).

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: Tarabai's regency came last, after Sambhaji and Rajaram.
- **B.** Wrong: Sambhaji reigned before Rajaram, not after.
- **C.** Wrong: Sambhaji and then Rajaram reigned first; Shivaji II's era began only via Tarabai's post-1700 regency.
- **D.** Correct: this is the secured succession order.

Trap: Skipping intermediate rulers to jump straight to the regency is the trap.

Q29. *[evidence]* What is the correct use of the coronation's royal era (Rajyabhisheka Shaka)?

- A. As bounded evidence that contemporaries dated documents/coins from the coronation year, showing assumed sovereignty.
- B. As proof that a modern national calendar reform was introduced.
- C. As evidence that all subsequent Maratha rulers used a different era.
- D. As proof that Kshatriya status was universally accepted without dispute.

Answer: A

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Correct: an era used on real documents/coinage is genuine, bounded evidence of a claimed sovereign status.
- **B.** Wrong: this overstates a royal dating era as a modern calendar reform.
- **C.** Wrong: the source point is that this specific era was used for later Maratha documents/coins.
- **D.** Wrong: the status debate itself shows contested, not universally accepted, status.

Trap: Turning bounded dating evidence into a sweeping modern-state claim is the trap.

Q30. *[evidence]* What is the correct use of the 'jama 100, hasil 55' worked example in Session 17?

- A. As the exact recorded revenue figures for a specific named Deccan district.
- B. As an illustrative model of the assessment-collection gap, not a verified historical statistic for any named district.
- C. As proof that all Mughal jagirs collected exactly fifty-five per cent of assessment.
- D. As evidence that be-jagiri and the jama-hasil gap are the same mechanism.

Answer: B

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: the text explicitly states this is a model, not a named district's real record.
- **B.** Correct: the example is explicitly a teaching model, not a recorded figure.
- **C.** Wrong: incidence varied by locality and cannot be generalised from one illustrative model.
- **D.** Wrong: the example illustrates the jama-hasil gap specifically, distinct from be-jagiri.

Trap: Mistaking an explicitly illustrative model for a verified historical statistic is the trap.

Q31. *[application]* An answer treats every claim in Topic 23 as equally certain. What is the correct fix using the topic's fact-risk ledger?

- A. Treat every claim, including contested details, as equally certain to save time.
- B. Delete all contested details from the answer, including the secure core events they attach to.
- C. Flag the ledger items needing care (such as early-fort wording, Afzal Khan's exact first blow, Agra's basket detail and revenue-incidence figures) with appropriately qualified language, while stating the secure core plainly.
- D. Assert that no claim in the topic can ever be stated with confidence.

Answer: C

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: this erases the necessary distinction between secure and contested claims.
- **B.** Wrong: contested detail should be qualified, not used to delete the secure event it is attached to.
- **C.** Correct: this matches the topic's own fact-risk ledger and its required qualified language.
- **D.** Wrong: many core facts are secure and should be stated plainly, not universally doubted.

Trap: Collapsing the secure/contested distinction into either blanket certainty or blanket doubt is the trap.

Q32. *[application]* How should an answer use the 2026 PIB conservation release on the Maratha forts?

- A. As proof of a new seventeenth-century administrative discovery.
- B. As identical in content and date to the UNESCO 2025 listing.
- C. As the primary source for Shivaji's military strategy.
- D. As a dated current-affairs bridge on site management, kept separate from the 2025 UNESCO listing and from historical argument.

Answer: D

Option-specific explanations:

- **A.** Wrong: it is a 2026 conservation-administration item, not seventeenth-century evidence.
- **B.** Wrong: the two are separate items with separate dates and functions.

- **C.** Wrong: military-strategy claims require period sources, not a modern conservation release.
- **D.** Correct: this respects both the date separation and the heritage-to-history boundary.

Trap: Collapsing a dated conservation update into historical or listing evidence is the trap.

VERIFIED PYQ LEDGER, 2018-2026

Year	Exam	Item	Routing	Marks/word-count	Key status
2026	Prelims/GS-I	No verified Topic-23 item located.	Not applicable - absence verified against the source-verification pass for this cycle.	-	No official key applicable (no verified question).
2024	Prelims	Bhatkal (coastal Karnataka trade-port item).	Routed to Topic 09 (Indian Ocean trade/ports), not Topic 23 - Bhatkal's routing is a trade-history point, not a Maratha-Deccan one.	Prelims, marks not item-stated (word-count field not applicable to Prelims).	Official key exists for the cycle; routed away from Topic 23 on subject-matter grounds.
2022	Prelims	Goa/Bijapur-linked options in a Portuguese/European-settlements question.	Routed to Modern-era European-settlements coverage, not Topic 23 - the tested content concerned European coastal settlement, not Maratha-Deccan state formation.	Prelims, marks not item-stated.	Official key exists for the cycle; routed away from Topic 23 on subject-matter grounds.
2019	Prelims	Jagirdar/Zamindar distinction item.	Routed to Topic 24 (Mughal administration/society-economy), not Topic 23 - the tested distinction is a general Mughal-administration term, not the Deccan jagirdari-crisis mechanism.	Prelims, marks not item-stated.	Official key exists for the cycle; routed away from Topic 23 on subject-matter grounds.
2018	Prelims	A question using the term 'Shivaji' in a non-Maratha (Modern-era) context.	Routed to Modern Indian History - a false keyword hit; the question's actual subject was a later-period figure/movement, not the seventeenth-century Maratha state.	Prelims, marks not item-stated.	Official key exists for the cycle; routed away from Topic 23 as a false keyword match.

No verified direct Topic-23 PYQ exists for 2018-2026, and no relevant 2026 item was found; only routing-ledger evidence for adjacent, non-Topic-23 items above is stated. Older-paper claims here rest on routing-ledger evidence only, not on independent inspection of the original papers.

SIX SOLVED MAINS ANSWERS (SYNCHRONISED WITH THE LEARNING SESSION)

Mains 1 - State formation / forts (10 marks)

Question: Examine the role of hill forts in structuring Maratha state formation under Shivaji.

Demand decoding: The demand word 'examine' requires a reasoned account of function, not a list; the question is bounded to forts as a structuring device, not a full biography.

Executable plan: 1) State the forts-as-network claim. 2) Give three named functions with evidence (Javli/Purandar/Panhala). 3) Add the qualification that forts alone did not suffice. 4) Close with a verdict.

Model answer (150 words):

Hill forts gave Shivaji's early state a repeatable operational structure rather than a single capital-centred base. The conquest of Javli in 1656 removed the More family's control and opened Maval-Konkan routes, converting a contested

pocket into a linked chain of garrisoned points. Purandar functioned as a negotiated strategic asset in 1665, when 23 of 35 forts passed to Mughal control while 12 were retained, showing forts as bargaining counters, not just walls. Panhala's 1660 siege and later recovery show forts sustaining defence and supply, not only shelter for retreat. Held forts allowed storage, intelligence and short-radius movement, letting a small core project authority over a wider, discontinuous territory. This capacity was necessary but not sufficient: forts needed garrisons, revenue and negotiated loyalty from deshmukhs and Mavali households to remain useful, and Purandar shows fort-holding itself was subject to negotiation and reversal. Forts therefore structured, without alone creating, Maratha state formation.

Marks-rationale (evidence-based): Marks reward three distinct, named fort-linked functions (route control, negotiated asset, siege/defence) plus the explicit qualification that forts required garrisons/loyalty/revenue to matter; an answer naming only one fort or treating forts as sufficient on their own loses marks.

Answer-specific improvement: A weaker answer would describe forts only as passive shelters; strengthen it by naming the specific mechanism (route control, bargaining counter, siege-defence) each fort illustrates.

Mains 2 - Sovereignty / administration (10 marks)

Question: Discuss how the 1674 coronation and the Ashtapradhan together expressed Shivaji's claim to sovereign authority.

Demand decoding: 'Discuss' requires linking two named institutions (coronation, Ashtapradhan) to one shared claim (sovereignty), not describing each in isolation.

Executable plan: 1) State the joint-claim thesis. 2) Coronation evidence: Gaga Bhatta, Kshatriya status, royal era. 3) Ashtapradhan evidence: eight ruler-responsible offices. 4) Qualify against modern-state or cabinet analogy. 5) Verdict.

Model answer (147 words):

The 1674 Raigad coronation and the Ashtapradhan together converted military success into a recognised claim to sovereign authority. Gaga Bhatta's validation of Kshatriya status let Shivaji be crowned rather than remain a subordinate chief, and the new royal era (Rajyabhisheka Shaka) let documents and coins be dated from the ruler's reign, a mark of asserted sovereignty. Alongside this ceremonial claim, the Ashtapradhan gave it administrative substance: eight officers, such as Peshwa, Amatya, Senapati and Nyayadhish, individually responsible to the ruler, covered finance, justice, correspondence and military command. This pairing shows sovereignty asserted in idiom and institution, not ceremony alone. The structure is not a modern constitutional monarchy or collective cabinet: offices were individually answerable to Shivaji, several combined civil and military duties, and no legislature existed. The coronation and council are best read as a regional, early-modern assertion of kingship through ritual legitimacy and functionally divided administration.

Marks-rationale (evidence-based): Full marks require both institutions linked to one claim, at least one named office beyond Peshwa, and the explicit anti-cabinet qualification; describing the coronation alone or listing all eight offices without the sovereignty link loses marks.

Answer-specific improvement: If an answer treats the Ashtapradhan as a modern cabinet, correct it by stressing individual ruler-responsibility rather than collective legislative accountability.

Mains 3 - Military-fiscal structure (20 marks)

Question: Analyse the military-fiscal structure that sustained Maratha state power under Shivaji, with reference to the army, the navy and revenue claims.

Demand decoding: 'Analyse' demands causal linkage between military organisation and fiscal claims, covering all three named elements (army, navy, revenue), not a description of any one alone.

Executable plan: 1) Thesis: military capacity and fiscal claims were mutually reinforcing. 2) Army: mixed cash-plunder-assignment pay, ganimi kava plus siege/battle (Salher). 3) Navy: littoral gunboats/grabs/gallivats/Sindhudurg. 4) Revenue: Annaji Datto assessment, chauth/sardeshmukhi distinction. 5) Qualification on assessment vs collection. 6) Verdict.

Model answer (225 words):

Maratha state power under Shivaji rested on a military-fiscal structure in which army, navy and revenue claims reinforced one another rather than functioning as separate departments. The army combined cash-paid regulars,

plunder shares and local assignments, and used mobile tactics (ganimi kava) alongside genuine siege defence at Panhala and a pitched battle at Salher (1671-72), giving flexible capacity across terrain and threat type. The navy was a regional littoral force of gunboats, grabs and gallivats based at coastal forts such as Sindhudurg, built to protect trade and contest the Sidis of Janjira rather than to command open-ocean routes. Sustaining both forces required revenue: Annaji Datto's assessment around 1679 measured and classified land to strengthen the jama (assessed demand), while chauth, a one-fourth protection-linked claim, and sardeshmukhi, a separate superior-deshmukh claim, extended fiscal reach beyond directly administered territory. These three elements were mutually reinforcing: assessed and claimed revenue paid regulars and financed the fleet, while army and navy protected the routes and coasts from which that revenue was drawn. The structure had real limits: assessment (jama) is not the same as realised collection (hasil), incidence of chauth varied by locality, and the navy's regional character meant it never became a deep-water force. The military-fiscal structure was therefore an integrated but bounded system, sufficient for regional power projection but resting on assessed rather than fully guaranteed resources.

Marks-rationale (evidence-based): High marks require all three elements (army, navy, revenue) integrated causally, at least one named fiscal term correctly distinguished (chauth vs sardeshmukhi, jama vs hasil), and the limits qualification; treating any one element in isolation or omitting the jama-hasil distinction caps the score.

Answer-specific improvement: A common weakness is listing army/navy/revenue separately without showing the causal loop; strengthen by explicitly stating how revenue funded forces and how forces protected revenue sources.

Mains 4 - Successors / war (15 marks)

Question: Examine how Sambhaji, Rajaram and Tarabai sustained Maratha resistance against Mughal power after 1680.

Demand decoding: 'Examine' requires tracing continuity and change in leadership and method across three named rulers, ending with an assessment of why resistance did not collapse.

Executable plan: 1) Thesis: leadership changed while resistance continued through adaptation. 2) Sambhaji's reign and 1689 execution. 3) Rajaram's shift to Gingee, escape before its 1698 fall. 4) Tarabai's regency for Shivaji II from 1700. 5) Qualification: decentralisation, bridge to Topic 25. 6) Verdict.

Model answer (208 words):

After Shivaji's death in 1680, Maratha resistance persisted through successive leaders who adapted method to circumstance rather than repeating one fixed strategy. Sambhaji held the Mughal war effort through the 1680s until his capture and execution in 1689, which removed a recognised negotiating head but did not end the capacity to resist. Rajaram shifted the centre of resistance southward to the distant fort of Gingee for strategic depth; the fort itself fell only in 1698, after Rajaram had already escaped, so its capture marked a logistical, not a leadership, loss. Following Rajaram's death in 1700, Tarabai led resistance as regent for her young son Shivaji II, organising patronage and command in his name rather than ruling in a purely personal capacity. Across these three phases, authority became progressively more decentralised, resting increasingly on autonomous commanders and forts rather than one unchallenged court. This decentralisation strengthened resistance in the short run by multiplying points of command the Mughals had to defeat, and it is best read as a qualified bridge toward the more openly confederate tendencies treated fully under the later, post-1707 period, without collapsing that later development into this phase. Maratha resistance therefore survived 1680-1700 through adaptive, increasingly distributed leadership rather than through any single successor's unbroken command.

Marks-rationale (evidence-based): Full marks require all three named successors with the correct fort-versus-person distinction for Gingee, Shivaji II named as the basis of Tarabai's regency, and an explicit, bounded bridge to later confederacy without overclaiming into Topic 25's territory.

Answer-specific improvement: If Gingee's fall is wrongly equated with Rajaram's capture, correct by stating the fort fell in 1698 only after his earlier escape.

Mains 5 - Annexation strategy (20 marks)

Question: Analyse why Aurangzeb's annexation of Bijapur and Golconda strengthened Mughal territorial claims but weakened Mughal capacity in the Deccan.

Demand decoding: 'Analyse' requires explaining the paradox causally: how the same act produced a formal gain and a real operational cost, using named administrative/military evidence.

Executable plan: 1) State the paradox thesis. 2) Territorial/formal gain: 1686 Bijapur, 1687 Golconda annexed. 3) Cost: displaced nobles/soldiers and unrealised claims on assignable land (paibaqi), long communications, jagirdari strain. 4) Add Gingee/Sambhaji war costs. 5) Qualification distinguishing map-conquest from governable authority. 6) Verdict.

Model answer (245 words):

Aurangzeb's annexation of Bijapur in 1686 and Golconda in 1687 extended Mughal territorial claims across the Deccan, yet the same act weakened the empire's practical capacity to govern the region it had formally absorbed. On the gain side, annexation removed two independent Deccan sultanates and placed their revenue and administrative apparatus nominally under Mughal control, a real extension of the map of imperial authority. On the cost side, annexation displaced Deccani nobles and soldiers who had served Bijapur and Golconda, and these displaced claimants added fresh demands for mansab and productive jagirs precisely when assignable land (paibaqi) and realised revenue were already strained, feeding the wider jagirdari crisis. Absorbing two additional sultanates lengthened supply and communication lines from the imperial core, while continuing war against Sambhaji, then Rajaram from Gingee (which fell only in 1698, after his escape), tied down large forces for years without a decisive end. The paradox is best read through the distinction between formal, map-level conquest and governable, revenue-realising authority: annexation produced the former quickly but the latter only partially and at high administrative-military cost. This does not mean the annexations were valueless; they were real territorial and fiscal gains, but they were achieved by adding unresolved claimant pressure and logistical strain rather than by a clean transfer of stable authority. Aurangzeb's Deccan strategy therefore illustrates how conquest and governability can diverge when absorbed elites, distance and prolonged war outrun an administration's capacity to convert new territory into secure, collectable revenue.

Marks-rationale (evidence-based): Top marks require the paradox stated causally (not just described), named displaced-claimant evidence (unrealised paibaqi assignments), the Gingee/Sambhaji war cost, and the map-conquest-versus-governable-authority distinction; omitting the claimant-pressure link to the jagirdari crisis caps the score.

Answer-specific improvement: A frequent gap is treating annexation as a cost-free gain; strengthen by explicitly naming displaced nobles/soldiers and their assignment claims as the mechanism connecting conquest to strain.

Mains 6 - Jagirdari crisis (15 marks)

Question: Examine the mechanisms behind the jagirdari crisis in the Mughal Deccan during Aurangzeb's reign.

Demand decoding: 'Examine' requires naming and linking multiple distinct mechanisms, not restating 'too many mansabdars, too few jagirs' as a single sufficient explanation.

Executable plan: 1) Thesis: multi-causal, not single-cause. 2) Rank inflation and claimant pressure (named groups). 3) Be-jagiri distinct from jama-hasil gap; paibaqi definition. 4) War disruption and short tenure/transfer/corruption. 5) Qualification. 6) Verdict.

Model answer (217 words):

The Deccan jagirdari crisis under Aurangzeb was not a single arithmetic imbalance but the outcome of several linked mechanisms operating together. Continuous campaigning drew Mughal khanazads and princes, Deccani nobles and soldiers absorbed after the Bijapur and Golconda annexations, and Maratha-origin mansabdars into competition for rank, producing rank inflation, an increase in ranked claimants that outran the supply of productive jagirs. This claimant pressure fed be-jagiri, a shortage of assignable productive jagirs, which is distinct from the jama-hasil gap, the difference between assessed revenue (jama) and revenue actually collected (hasil) on land that was assigned; a jagir could exist on paper yet yield little real income. Paibaqi, land recorded as unassigned or awaiting assignment, compounded the problem because its paper availability did not guarantee productive, collectable income once granted. War disruption reduced agricultural output and made collection harder in contested tracts, while short tenures

and frequent transfers gave jagirdars incentive to extract quickly rather than invest, encouraging corruption and straining troop maintenance obligations tied to rank. These mechanisms reinforced one another: rank inflation raised claims on a shrinking productive base, disrupted collection widened the jama-hasil gap, and short-tenure extraction worsened both. The jagirdari crisis is therefore best explained as a compounding, multi-causal fiscal-administrative strain rather than a single decision or a simple excess of claimants over posts.

Marks-rationale (evidence-based): Full marks require naming and distinguishing at least three mechanisms (rank inflation, be-jagiri, jama-hasil gap, paibaqi, short-tenure/transfer corruption) with the specific claimant groups; collapsing all mechanisms into 'too many mansabdars' alone loses significant marks.

Answer-specific improvement: If be-jagiri and the jama-hasil gap are merged, correct by stating one concerns jagir supply and the other concerns assessment-versus-collection on an already-assigned jagir.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES (WORKBOOK SUMMARY)

- Geography (Sahyadri/Maval/Konkan) enabled but did not by itself create Maratha state power.
- Shahji's career was mobile Deccan service (Bijapur, a Nizam Shahi claimant, and the wider Golconda-adjacent field), not hereditary nationalism.
- Javli (1656) converted a contested pocket into route/node control; Afzal Khan's death (1659) is secure even where the blow-by-blow account is genre-dependent.
- Purandar (1665) transferred 23 of 35 forts and granted Sambhaji mansab 5000 - a negotiated incorporation, not a final surrender.
- Agra (1666) was a status/rank crisis Shivaji escaped; the exact escape method carries variable source weight.
- The 1674 coronation founded a royal era (Rajyabhisheka Shaka) and asserted Kshatriya sovereignty; the Ashtapradhan's eight offices were individually ruler-responsible, not a collective cabinet.
- Annaji Datto's c.1679 assessment strengthened estimation (jama); it is not the same as realised collection (hasil).
- Chauth (one-fourth, protection-linked) and sardeshmukhi (a separate superior-deshmukh claim) must stay distinct.
- Military remuneration mixed cash, plunder and local assignments; ganimi kava coexisted with siege defence (Panhala) and pitched battle (Salher).
- The navy was a littoral force (gunboats, grabs, gallivats) based at forts like Sindhudurg - regional capacity, not a blue-water fleet.
- Religious legitimacy combined a genuine Hindu royal idiom with Persianate institutions and Muslim personnel.
- Sambhaji's 1689 execution decentralised, not ended, resistance; Rajaram used Jinji (Gingee) for depth and had already escaped when the fort fell in 1698; Tarabai regented for the named heir Shivaji II.
- Bijapur (1686) and Golconda (1687) annexations added formal territory and displaced Deccani nobles/soldiers whose assignment claims fed jagir pressure.
- The jagirdari crisis combines rank inflation (named Mughal, Deccani and Maratha-origin claimant groups), be-jagiri, the jama-hasil gap, paibaqi ambiguity, war disruption and short-tenure/transfer corruption - not one single cause.
- Boundary discipline: Topic 18 carries policy through 1657, Topic 22 carries religion/Rajput/North India, Topic 24 carries society/economy/culture, Topic 25 carries the post-1707 confederate period.
- No verified direct Topic-23 PYQ exists for 2018-2026; only routing-ledger evidence exists for adjacent items.